Bodo Language Grammar & Script Orthography Guide

Phonology, High/Low Tone System, Nominal Cases, Classifiers & Verbal Syntax

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1. Vowel System & Tonal Contrasts

Bodo is a tonal language characterized by High (Falling) Tone and Low (Level) Tone. Tone distinction shifts meaning across identical phonemic strings: e.g., 'हा' with high tone = 'to be able', with low tone = 'land/earth'.

Vowel	Devanagari	IPA	Vocabulary Example
a	आ / ा	/a/	हा (ha - land)
i	इ / ि	/i/	फसि (fisa - child)
u	उ / ु	/u/	दुइ (dui - water)
e	ए / े	/e/	बे (be - this)
o	अ / ो	/o/	अँथ (wnth - end)
w	अ' / ौ / ो	//	गोजौ (gwojwo - high)

2. Grammatical Case Markers (Declension)

Case	Suffix	Syntactic Function	Example
Nominative	-Ø (unmarked)	Subject of clause	मानसयि फैबाय (The person arrived)
Accusative	-खौ (-khwo)	Direct object	दाउसनिखौ नुबाय (Saw the bird)
Genitive	-नि (-ni)	Possession / Origin	गामनि मानसि (Person of the village)
Dative	-नो (-nw)	Indirect object / Beneficiary	बहिानो हर (Give to him)
Instrumental	-जों (-jwng)	Means / accompaniment	जोंजों थां (Go with us)
Locative	-आव (-ao)	Location / in / at	नआव दं (Is inside the house)
Ablative	-नफि्राय (-nifray)	Separation / motion from	गुवाहाटीनफि्राय (From Guwahati)

3. Numeral Classifiers (Definiteness & Shapes)

Classifier	Semantic Category	Illustrative Example
सा (sa)	Human beings	मानसि सा-से (one person)
मा (ma)	Animals & living creatures	मोसौ मा-नै (two cows)
गं (gong)	Houses, long tools, utensils	न गं-थाम (three houses)
थां / थाइ (thai)	Fruits, round spherical items	फथिाइ थाइ-से (one fruit)
गां (gang)	Flat thin objects, paper, leaf	बलिाइ गां-से (one leaf)

4. Verbal Suffixes, Tense, Aspect & Negation

Aspect / Tense	Suffix Marker	Example Sentence
Present Indefinite	-ओ / -यो (-w / -yw)	आं जानो लुबैयो (I wish to eat)
Present Continuous	-दों (-dwng)	बहि फैदों (He is coming)
Past Indefinite	-बाय (-bay)	आं जाबाय (I ate / have eaten)
Past Habitual / Past	-मोन (-mwn)	बेयाव थायोमोन (Used to reside here)
Future	-गोन (-gwn)	जों गाबोन थांगोन (We will go tomorrow)
Negative Marker	Prefix दा- (da-) / Suffix -आ (-a)	दाथां (don't go), थाङा (does not go)